

Run it once. Then run it *again*.

The practical playbook for building your first repeatable AI-powered workflow.

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A practical, founder-led playbook for building your first repeatable AI-powered workflow.

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Introduction

Before You Start

In v1 you shipped something real. That was a one-off: one brief, one build, one launch. This playbook is about the thing that comes next, which is doing useful work again and again without starting from a blank page each time.

By the end you'll have a workflow you've run several times. It will draft content for you, and a free tool will publish or send it at a time you choose, even while you're doing something else. You stay in charge of checking it. AI does the drafting, a scheduling tool does the sending, and you do the judging.

You don't need to have read v1, though if you did, you'll reuse what you built.

When you get stuck

You will hit hurdles setting things up. A button isn't where you expected, a tool asks for a setting you don't understand, or something doesn't work the first time. This is where AI is most useful.

Describe the problem to Claude, and paste in any error message or a screenshot. If the answer isn't clear, say so and ask it to explain in simpler terms. Keep going one step at a time until it's resolved.

What a Workflow Actually Is

A workflow is a set of steps you design once and run again whenever the same job comes up. AI does the work you'd normally do by hand. You decide how much of it to check.

Think of an invoice template. The first time, you set up the layout, your details and your payment terms. After that, each invoice only needs the new client, date and amount. A workflow works the same way: the structure is saved, and each run you only add what's new.

One-off versus repeatable

In v1, you wrote a brief and built one thing. If you had to build a second website tomorrow, you'd likely rewrite the brief from memory, get a different result, and spend the same time again.

A workflow removes that. You work out the steps once and save them. Each time after that, you supply the new information and review the output.

Three signs a task should be a workflow

1. **It happens regularly.** Weekly, fortnightly or monthly. A once-a-year task usually isn't worth the setup.
2. **The steps are roughly the same each time.** Collect some information, turn it into something, send it somewhere.
3. **The output has the same format each time.** A post, an email, a summary, a list. The content changes; the format doesn't.

If a task meets all three, it's a candidate.

A real example

Every month at Surreal, we send our investors an update. It used to take over an hour to pull the numbers and news together and write it up from scratch.

Now it runs as a workflow. A spreadsheet fills itself from our reporting system. AI reads that spreadsheet, scans the month's activity (Slack, our team messaging app, and emails) for news worth sharing, and drafts the update in the same structure every time: a short summary, the numbers, what went well and what didn't.

It now takes under 10 minutes. That time goes on quality assurance, or QA: reading the draft, checking the numbers and making amends before it's sent.

How much of this is automated?

STEP	SURREAL'S INVESTOR UPDATE	YOUR WORKFLOW IN THIS PLAYBOOK
Collect the information	Automatic, from our reporting system, Slack and email	You paste it in, in a few minutes
Draft the content	AI	AI
Check and make amends	A person, in under 10 minutes	You
Deliver it	Sent once checked	A free scheduling tool, at the time you choose

Your version starts with you pasting the information in. Connecting AI directly to your email and messages, so it collects everything itself, comes later in this series. The structure is the same either way.

Not every workflow needs a check

Some workflows can run with no review at all. These are usually binary tasks: jobs with a clear yes-or-no answer. Is this email an invoice? Has this form been filled in? Is this date in the next seven days? When the right answer is easy to define, AI can sort, tag or file things without you looking.

Workflows that produce writing other people will read, like posts and emails, are different. Keep a check on those until you've seen them come out right many times in a row.

The habit trap

Many people avoid automating tasks they've always done by hand. Part of it is habit: it's how the job has always been done. Part of it is worry that quality will drop if AI does it.

Quality doesn't come from doing every step yourself. It comes from three things you control:

1. **An iterative process.** The first output is a draft. Each round of feedback improves the next one, and each improvement gets saved so you never repeat it.
2. **Candid feedback.** Tell AI exactly what's wrong and why. "This sounds like an ad, remove the exclamation marks" works. "Make it better" doesn't.
3. **Final checkpoints.** Decide where a person must look before anything goes out. You can remove a checkpoint later, once the output has earned it.

Done this way, a workflow often produces more consistent work than doing it by hand, because it applies the same standard every time.

15-MINUTE EXERCISE

Pick three tasks from this list that you do in a normal week, or add your own:

- Writing the grocery list
- Replying to an email you get often, like a booking request or a common question
- Planning the week's meals, workouts or schedule
- Writing a birthday or thank-you message
- Summarising a long email, newsletter or document
- Drafting a social media post

For each one, open Claude and ask it to do the task, with a few lines of context. You don't need to send or publish anything. The point is to see how wide the range of everyday tasks AI can take on is.

Then note which of the three tasks met all three signs above, and which saved you the most time. That's a strong candidate for your workflow.

Pick Your Path

There are two paths in this playbook. Pick one now and stick with it to the end. You can always come back and build the other.

Path 1: Share what you built

You built something in v1, or you have something of your own. This path turns it into a regular stream of posts that AI drafts for you each week.

If you built a game, choose one:

- **Weekly update post.** What changed this week and what's coming next. Every new level, tweak or fix is something to post about.
- **Challenge of the week.** A repeating post that gives people a reason to play: a question to answer, a score to beat, a puzzle to solve. AI produces a new one each week from the same template.

If you built a website: become its content helper. Each week, AI drafts posts for the business, such as a practical tip, an answer to a common customer question, or a seasonal reminder. If the site is for someone else, send them the drafts to approve and post themselves, so you don't need access to their accounts.

No users or feedback yet?

You don't need players, customers or feedback to build any of these workflows. Where a prompt asks for player messages or feedback, ask AI to create realistic placeholder examples instead, and use them to test the whole process. When real feedback arrives, swap it in.

PLACEHOLDER INPUT PROMPT

"I'm testing a workflow and don't have real data yet. Write [number] realistic examples of [player feedback / customer questions / weekly notes] for [describe your game, website or situation]. Make them varied, including some negative ones."

Path 2: A personal workflow

This path is for everyday tasks that take up time every week. Each option below is common, repeats regularly, and saves real time or money once it's set up.

- **Weekly meal plan and shopping list.** Tell AI what's in the fridge, your budget and how many people you're feeding. It drafts a week of dinners and one shopping list grouped by section. Sent to your household every Sunday.
- **Family week ahead.** Paste in school newsletters, sport fixtures and appointment reminders. AI pulls out every date, deadline and thing to bring, and drafts one summary. Sent to you, and anyone else running the household, every Sunday night.
- **Job applications.** Each time you find a role worth applying for, paste in the job ad and your CV (resume). AI drafts a tailored cover letter and suggests which parts of your CV to adjust. You review it and apply.

The first two go out on a schedule. The third runs each time a new job ad comes up, so it doesn't need a scheduling tool.

Which one suits you?

PATH	SUITS YOU IF	WHAT YOU'LL PRODUCE	WHERE IT ENDS UP
1: Weekly update	You built a game	A weekly post on what changed and what's next	Social media
1: Challenge of the week	You built a game	A weekly challenge post linking to the game	Social media
1: Content helper	You built a website	A weekly batch of posts for the business	Social media, or sent to the owner to approve
2: Meal plan	You want to save time and money on food	A weekly meal plan and shopping list	Your household's inbox
2: Family week ahead	You juggle school, sport and appointments	A weekly summary of dates and to-dos	Your household's inbox
2: Job applications	You're looking for work	A tailored cover letter for each role	Your job application

15-MINUTE EXERCISE

Pick your path. Then finish this sentence and write it somewhere you'll see it again:

"Every [how often, or each time something happens], I want [what] to land in [where], so that [why it matters to me]."

For example: "Every Friday, I want a post about my game's latest update to go up on Instagram, so that people have a regular reason to try it."

If you're stuck choosing, paste both paths into Claude with a few lines about your situation, and ask it which one fits you better and why. Then decide for yourself.

Map It Before You Build It

Before you write any prompts, map the workflow. Ten minutes here saves hours of fixing later.

In software, nobody builds a new feature without first writing a specification: a short description of what it should do, who it's for and what finished looks like. Your workflow map is the specification for your workflow.

The five parts of every workflow

1. **When:** how often it runs, or what starts it. "Every Sunday at 4pm" or "each time I find a job worth applying for."
2. **Inputs:** the information that goes in. Notes, feedback, newsletters, a job ad.
3. **Steps:** what happens to the inputs, in order. Summarise, pick the highlights, draft, check.
4. **Output:** what comes out. One post, three posts, an email, a cover letter.
5. **Destination:** where it ends up. Instagram, an inbox, a job application.

If you can fill in all five, you have a workflow. If one is blank, fill that gap before you build.

A real example: turning feedback into themes

At Surreal, we believed our onboarding emails were enough to guide new users. Onboarding means the steps that help a new user get set up and confident with a product.

Feedback told a different story. The emails weren't the problem. The lack of guidance inside the platform itself was. We only saw this because we ran a feedback workflow: all feedback collected in one place and grouped into themes by AI, rather than read one message at a time.

That changed how the decision got made. Instead of one person's hunch, we had multiple reference points to bring to the team. The conversation was easy to start, and fixing it became a priority project.

You don't need customers to use this. Feedback from friends who tried your v1 project works. If you have none yet, use the placeholder input prompt from Chapter 2 to test the process. Path 1 game builders use this workflow in Chapter 6.

Two completed maps

PART	PATH 1: GAME UPDATES	PATH 2: MEAL PLAN
When	Every Friday morning	Every Sunday at 4pm
Inputs	Notes on what changed this week, plus any player messages	What's in the fridge and pantry, budget, number of people
Steps	Summarise the changes, pick the best player comment, draft the post, review it	Plan dinners using what's on hand, write one shopping list by section, review it
Output	One short post with a link to the game	A meal plan and shopping list in one email
Destination	Instagram, scheduled for Friday at 6pm	The household inbox, scheduled for Sunday at 5pm

Let AI interview you

You don't have to fill in the map alone. AI can ask you questions, one at a time, until the map is complete.

MAPPING PROMPT

"I'm building my first repeatable workflow. I'm a beginner. Here's what I want: [paste your sentence from Chapter 2]. Help me map it using five parts: when it runs, the inputs, the steps, the output, and where it ends up. Ask me one question at a time. Don't suggest any tools yet. When we're done, give me the finished map as a simple table."

The line "don't suggest any tools yet" matters. Choose tools last. Once the map is clear, the right tool is usually obvious.

15-MINUTE EXERCISE

Run the mapping prompt. Answer each question honestly, including "I don't know" where that's true. AI can help you work out an answer, but only if it knows there's a gap.

Save the finished map. You'll use it in every chapter from here.

Build Your Kit

Your workflow needs three things saved in one place: a standing brief, a workflow prompt, and a Project to keep them in. Set them up once, and each future run takes minutes.

Piece 1: The standing brief

In v1, you wrote an operating system: a paragraph of context about you and your work. The standing brief is the same idea, focused on this one workflow. It tells AI who it's writing for, what tone to use and what to avoid, so you never explain it twice.

STANDING BRIEF TEMPLATE

"This workflow is for [your path from Chapter 2]. The audience is [who reads it]. The tone is [three words]. Every output should [the non-negotiables, e.g. be under 100 words, include the link]. Never [what you don't want, e.g. use hashtags, sound like an ad, make up facts]. If you're unsure about a fact, ask me rather than guessing."

The last line matters. AI sometimes fills gaps with confident-sounding details that aren't true. Telling it to ask instead of guess reduces that.

Piece 2: The workflow prompt

The workflow prompt is your template. It's the instruction you paste each time the workflow runs, with blanks for the new inputs. Your map from Chapter 3 tells you what to include.

EXAMPLE WORKFLOW PROMPT (PATH 1, GAME UPDATES)

"It's time for this week's game update. Here's what changed: [your notes]. Here's what players said: [paste messages, or write 'none yet']". Using my standing brief, draft one post about the update. If there's player feedback, pick the best comment to feature, and note whether I have permission to share it. Then give me one alternative opening line."

EXAMPLE WORKFLOW PROMPT (PATH 2, MEAL PLAN)

"It's time for this week's meal plan. Here's what's in the fridge and pantry: [list]. Our budget is [amount] and we're feeding [number] people. Using my standing brief, plan [number] dinners that use what we already have first. Then write one shopping list grouped by section: fruit and veg, meat, dairy, pantry. Flag anything you've assumed rather than been told."

Piece 3: A Project to keep it in

In Claude, a Project is a workspace that keeps instructions and files for every conversation you start inside it. Think of it as a labelled folder: anything in the folder's instructions, Claude reads at the start of every chat in that folder.

Paste your standing brief into the Project's instructions. Save your workflow prompt as a note or file inside it. From then on, each run is a new chat in the same Project, and the brief is already there.

If you can't find Projects, or it works differently by the time you read this, ask: "I've never heard of Claude Projects. Explain what it is and walk me through setting one up, step by step." No Projects at all? A note on your phone with the brief and prompt works too.

The first run

Run the workflow once yourself before you schedule anything.

1. Collect this week's inputs: your notes, messages, newsletters or job ad.
2. Start a new chat inside your Project. Paste your workflow prompt with the blanks filled in.
3. Read the output as the person receiving it would.
4. Give feedback, as you learned in v1: what worked, what didn't, and why.
5. Repeat until you'd be happy to publish or send it.

Then check what you had to correct, and why. If you told AI three times to stop using exclamation marks, the problem isn't this output. It's a missing line in your standing brief. **Update the template, not just the output.**

UPDATE-THE-TEMPLATE PROMPT

"Look back at the feedback I gave you in this conversation. Which of my corrections should become permanent rules? Rewrite my standing brief and workflow prompt to include them, so I don't have to give this feedback again."

15-MINUTE EXERCISE

Set up your three pieces and do your first run. Don't publish or send anything yet. Finish with the update-the-template prompt and save the new versions in your Project. In Chapter 5, you'll set up delivery.

Let It Run While You're Away

In this chapter, you'll check your output and hand it to a free scheduling tool that publishes or sends it at the time you choose.

What a scheduling tool does

A scheduling tool holds your finished post or email and publishes it at a set time, even when your phone is off. It works like a scheduled payment in your banking app: you set it up, choose the date, and it goes out without you.

The tool doesn't write or check anything. What you give it is exactly what goes out, so the checking step is never skipped.

Pick your tool

All of these have a free option. If a name is new to you, ask AI what it is and whether it's free before you sign up.

TOOL	GOOD FOR	FREE VERSION	WATCH OUT FOR
Meta Business Suite	Facebook and Instagram posts	Free	Only covers Meta's own apps, and needs a business or creator account
Buffer	Several social platforms in one place	Up to 3 accounts, 10 posts queued per account at a time	The queue limit means planning about a week or two ahead
Schedule send in your email	Path 2 meal plans and family week-ahead emails	Built into Gmail and most other email apps	Check the time zone before you schedule

Two cases don't need a scheduler. Path 1 content helpers send the checked batch to the business owner with suggested dates, and the owner posts it. Path 2 job applications go straight into the application once you've reviewed them.

Batch your posts

Path 1 builders can run the workflow once and produce several posts at a time, rather than one a day.

BATCHING PROMPT

"Using my standing brief and these inputs: [paste], draft [number] posts to go out over the next [time period]. Make each one different: vary the opening, the angle and the length. Number them and suggest a day for each. Flag any post where you've had to guess at a fact."

One sitting and one review gives you a week or two of posts in the queue. Path 2 weekly emails run once a week, so there's nothing to batch.

Before anything gets scheduled

Read every item before it goes out. Check three things:

- **Is it true?** AI can state incorrect things confidently. Check names, dates, prices and claims against what you know.
- **Does it sound like you?** If it reads like an ad or a stranger wrote it, rewrite it.
- **Is it safe to share?** No private details about other people, and nothing from a player or friend they haven't agreed to share. Family week-ahead emails often include children's school details, so send them only to people who should have them.

Then schedule it. If the tool is new to you, ask: "I'm using [tool] for the first time. Walk me through scheduling one post or email, step by step, assuming I've never used it."

If something doesn't work, paste the error message or a screenshot into Claude and ask what to do next. Keep asking until it's resolved.

15-MINUTE EXERCISE

Set up your tool and schedule your first output:

- **Path 1:** schedule three posts across the next week.
- **Path 2, weekly emails:** schedule this week's meal plan or family week ahead.
- **Path 2, job applications:** run the workflow on one real job ad and review the cover letter.

The next day, check that it went out as planned.

Run It Again, and Again

A workflow proves itself on the second and third runs, not the first. This chapter takes you through both.

On the first run you're paying close attention. The second run shows whether your setup holds up when you're busy or tired.

Watch for drift

Over several runs, outputs tend to drift. They start to sound the same, and the same phrases come back. A post that felt fresh in week one feels repetitive by week four.

This is normal maintenance, not failure. When you notice it, run the update-the-template prompt from Chapter 4 and add a line to your standing brief, such as "don't open with a question" or "vary the length between posts."

Keep a run log

After each run, write three lines in a note:

1. The date, and how long the run took.
2. What you had to fix.
3. What you changed in your template.

After three runs, check the log. The time should drop and the list of fixes should get shorter. If it doesn't, your standing brief needs more detail.

Use feedback to plan the next run

Path 1 game builders: this is where the feedback workflow from Chapter 3 comes in. Once a few people have played, collect every comment, message and reply in one place and run the prompt below. No players yet? Test it with placeholder feedback from Chapter 2:

FEEDBACK THEMES PROMPT

"Here's all the feedback I've had on my game: [paste everything]. Group it into themes. For each theme, tell me how many people mentioned it and quote one example. Separate what lots of people said from what one person said. Then suggest the one change that would make the biggest difference, and draft a short post telling players it's coming."

The feedback becomes your next improvement, and the improvement becomes your next post. When you make the change, Chapter 8 of v1 covers re-shipping it.

Path 2: ask the people who receive your emails what they'd want more or less of. Meal plans too repetitive? Family summary missing sport times? Add their answers to your standing brief. For job applications, note which cover letters got a response and ask AI what they had in common.

The finish line

You're done with this playbook when you've run your workflow three times and you can answer yes to all of these:

- ☐ Each run took less time than the one before.
- ☐ You checked every output before it went out.
- ☐ You updated your template at least once based on what you learned.
- ☐ Something went out on schedule while you were doing something else (job applications: skip this one).

15-MINUTE EXERCISE

Do your second run this week, start to finish, and fill in your run log. Book your third run in your calendar now. A workflow only works if the next run happens.

What's next: v3, Mastering AI

By now you'll have noticed the manual parts of your workflow: pasting notes in, copying drafts out, and moving things between tools by hand.

v3 is about removing those. It covers setting your AI tools up properly: giving them lasting context about you and your work, connecting them to where your information already lives, such as your email and calendar, and choosing the right settings for each job. Set up well, every workflow you run needs less input from you and gets faster. That's why v3 is the leverage point of this series.

v4 then brings it together: several workflows and AI agents (AI that takes actions for you, not just answers questions) working as one setup.

You found a task that repeats, built a workflow for it, and ran it three times. Everything in v3 builds on that.